

COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 5

Deeper Core Belief Work & Reviewing Experiments *Fictional Educational Example — Full Detailed*

SESSION INFORMATION

Client:	RK (35 y/o Male)	Therapist:	Dr. A.
Session #:	5 of 16	Focus:	Deeper core belief work + Experiments review

PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

Client continuing to show good progress with experiments and thought records. Belief in perfectionistic thought now around 40%. Today we will do deeper work on the core belief using historical review and advantages/disadvantages analysis. Also review Worry Time and problem-solving attempts.

SESSION START & HOMEWORK REVIEW

Therapist: Good morning, RK. How was your week? Let's review the homework first.

Client: Worry Time is becoming a habit. I'm postponing worries more easily. The problem-solving steps helped with one work issue — I managed to push back on an extra task without feeling too guilty.

Therapist: That's excellent. And how did the thought records and balanced thinking go?

Client: The belief in "I have to be perfect..." is down to about 40% now. The experiments are really helping me see that small imperfections don't lead to disaster.

DEEPER WORK ON CORE BELIEFS – HISTORICAL REVIEW

Therapist: Today I'd like to go a bit deeper into where this belief "I have to be perfect or I'm not good enough" might have come from. This is called ****Historical Review****. It can help us understand the roots and weaken the belief further.

Client: Okay, I'm open to that.

Therapist: When did you first start feeling that you had to be perfect to be accepted or valued?

Client: Probably in school. My parents were very focused on academics. Getting 95% was good, but 100% was expected. I remember feeling like anything less than the top was disappointing to them.

Therapist: That makes a lot of sense. So the belief started as a way to gain approval and avoid disappointment. As a child, being perfect helped you feel safe and valued. But as an adult, that same rule is now causing a lot of stress and preventing you from taking reasonable risks.

Client: Yeah... I never really connected it to my childhood before.

Therapist: This is common. Many of our strongest beliefs were formed when we were younger to help us survive or get needs met. The problem is they often become outdated. Would you be willing to update this old rule for your current adult life?

Client: Yes. I think the new rule could be: "I can be good enough and still make mistakes. Being human includes imperfection."

ADVANTAGES VS DISADVANTAGES OF THE OLD BELIEF

Therapist: Let's also look at the advantages and disadvantages of holding on to the old belief "I must be perfect."

Advantages (what it gave you in the past):

- Helped me get good grades and recognition from parents
- Made me work very hard and achieve a lot
- Gave me a sense of control

Disadvantages (current cost):

- Constant anxiety and stress
- Poor sleep and burnout
- Difficulty saying no or taking reasonable risks
- Strained relationship with wife because I'm irritable and withdrawn

Therapist: When you look at both sides, which list feels heavier right now?

Client: The disadvantages are much heavier now. The old belief is costing me too much.

HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

Therapist: For this week:

1. Continue daily diary + Worry Time
2. Write down the new balanced belief and read it every morning
3. Do one more behavioral experiment: Share an idea or opinion in a meeting without over-preparing it
4. Notice and record any situations where the old perfectionistic belief shows up and practice using the new belief instead

SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

Therapist: Today we did deeper work on the roots of your belief and looked at the advantages vs disadvantages. We also created a new, more flexible belief. What stood out most for you?

Client: Understanding where the belief came from helped me see it as an old rule that doesn't fit my life anymore. The advantages/disadvantages list made it very clear.

Therapist: Excellent. Any questions?

Client: No, I'm clear on everything.

POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client responded very well to historical review and advantages/disadvantages analysis.
- Core belief work progressing well (belief now significantly reduced).
- Behavioral experiments continuing to provide powerful evidence.
- Next session: Review new experiments, continue core belief work if needed, introduce worry postponement more formally or move toward relapse prevention planning in later sessions.

Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.